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Why Small Libraries Still Matter in a Searchable World

When my town voted to cut the opening hours of the Elm Street branch library, the main argument was that everything is online now. The council was not wrong that information is easier to find than ever. But a library was never only a store of information, and treating it as one misses what the building does for the people who use it.

The first thing a small library offers is a quiet, heated room that asks nothing of you. For students who share a bedroom with siblings, or workers between shifts, that room is the only place to sit for an hour without buying something. No search engine provides a chair.

The second is a librarian, a person whose job is to help you ask a better question. When I was writing my first research paper, the librarian did not hand me an answer; she showed me why my question was too broad and which three books would tell me whether it was worth asking at all.

Finally, a library is a shared promise that knowledge belongs to everyone, not only to those who can pay for subscriptions. Cutting its hours quietly breaks that promise for the people who need it most.

> *“A library is not a luxury but one of the necessities of life.” Henry Ward Beecher*

Works Cited

Klinenberg, Eric. Palaces for the People. Crown, 2018.

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